BLANKED OUT Mamata Banerjee with Matua and Muslim community members at an anti-SIR protest, Kolkata, Mar. 7



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

▶ WEST BENGAL

SIDE EFFECTS OF SIR: BLOC DELETIONS

The BJP faces an ironic reversal of its objectives with voter list revision, as Matuas face mass deletions. A big slice of TMC's minority bloc hangs in the balance too

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

IT'S NO ARCANE LEGAL DEBATE. THE TREMORS are being felt on the streets of Kolkata. The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in West Bengal still has six million names left in suspended animation. If those stay disenfranchised after the adjudication process, the electorate would stand at 64.5 million—nearly 10 per cent slimmer than 70.8 million, the number before the process started. That's higher than what the 'third front' polled in the 2021 assembly election. Not a slice of the pie that will vacate the house quietly.

The confrontation reached a flashpoint on March 8 when the full bench of the Election Commission of India (ECI), headed by chief Gyanesh Kumar, arrived in the city to review preparedness ahead of the 2026 assembly poll. As the convoy travelled through Kolkata that evening, Left cadre waved black flags and raised "go back" slogans. Other protesters picked up in the morning when Kumar visited the Kalighat temple to offer puja. Chief minister Mamata Banerjee had been on dharna since March 6, accusing the ECI and the Centre of carrying out large-scale, targeted voter deletions, but suspended it on March 10, after the Supreme Court directed an appellate tribunal to be formed to hear appeals of voter deletion.

If the SIR was supposed to do a spring-cleaning on flawed data piled up for years, it has had the opposite effect in Bengal. It has opened a Pandora's box of demographic and political uncertainties. And the parties are vocalising it bluntly. "Genuine voters have been deleted deliberately by the BJP and the ECI," Mamata said at a public event after the final SIR list was released on February 28. "I am shocked. This is a very sad and inhumane state of affairs."

IRONIC PATTERN

Three distinct patterns emerging from the SIR data are driving political anxieties. The first is an ironic one, and relates to reserved constituencies. Across the state's 84 Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe assembly seats,